Collection from Chasing Utopia: A Hybrid

By Nikki Giovanni

INTRODUCTION

"Words are the lifeblood for writers." Writers spend their days imagining just the right combination of words put together in such a way that a beautiful sentence or idea emerges. When this happens, what is written can actually take the reader beyond the page - creating images, pictures, colors, sounds, and smells that transport the reader to another world, a world beyond the everyday realities of life.

In this collection of poetry from Chasing Utopia by Nikki Giovanni, the joy of words is celebrated.

FOR HAKI MADHUBUTI (a prose poem)

Words are the lifeblood of writers. Though I must admit I don't know if we dream in words or if we word our dreams.

Words are like quilts. You have to put a bunch together to make something warm and comforting or patch together something that will prick and scratch the spirit. No matter how we weave this experience, we sculpt an idea and shape a phrase.

A phrase. Usually we find phrases to describe whatever it is. No word is sufficient to stand alone. Not even strong words like FREEDOM or soft words like LOVE. They all are better when added to . . . for example FOR ALL . . . or *je t'aime*. Love phrases work in all languages. The human experiment has turned on many important phrases WE THE PEOPLE, **taxation without representation** and even things like REMEMBER THE MAINE. There are other political phrases like LIBERTE, EGALITE, FRATERNITE. I especially like WE SHALL OVERCOME. There are personal phrases like **Yes.** Which may be the only one-word phrase we ever use. **No** requires a bit more. There are personal phrases such as **You Look Beautiful** and I **am so proud of you** but maybe that's a sentence not a phrase.

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The human imagination is the engine that has carried us from caves in Europe, from the rain forests of South America, from the lush and mineral-rich lands of Africa, from the beautiful amber waves of North America, from the roaring seas and the frozen tundra, in fact, to wherever humans gather . . .

TRANSITION

And one of the most beautiful uses of words is to create poetry . . . it is profoundly significant.

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF POETRY

Poetry is as necessary

To life

As salt is to stew

As garlic is to pasta

As perfume is to summer nights

As shaving lotion is to mornings

As your smile is to

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My happiness

Poetry is as significant

To life

As yeast is to bread

As butter is to toast

As grapes are to wine

As sugar is to lemons

How else will we get Lemonade

Poetry is to me

Your voice

Your touch

Your laughter

That feeling at the end of day

That I am

Not alone

TRANSITION

Lucille Clifton, an American poet from Buffalo, New York, explains . . . "The first poets didn't come out of a classroom, that poetry began when somebody walked off of a savanna or out of a cave and looked up at the sky with wonder and said, "Ahhh." That was the first poem. – Lucille Clifton

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I WISH I COULD LIVE (IN A BOOK)
(for Charles A. Smith, Jr.)

I wish I could live

In a book

All wrapped up

In my fairy Godmother's arms

Or sitting with my

Cave Mother baking dinosaur

Eggs

If I lived

In a book

I could fly With Ali Baba

And even though it's not right

To steal

The Forty Thieves are

Pretty cool

Maybe there would be

A book about me

One day

Just a little girl being brave

In a world where water

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Is in short supply

But everybody

Has a gun

I don't think

That's a good idea

I'd rather be in

A book

Making biscuits

On the frontier

TRANSITION

Poetry is described by Dennis Gabor as "plucking at the heartstrings, and making music with them."

I WISH I COULD LIVE (IN MUSIC)

I wish I could live

In music

I'd be all

Kinds:

Opera arias

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Folk telling news

Minuets

Hoedown dancing calling square dancers

Whoa!

Bring me some

Disco

Yeah I'd be a Spiritual

And then a wonderful

Foot-stomping

Gospel tune

Some blues-almost forgot

The Blues

And we need

Jazz

I need me "A-Tisket A-Tasket"

Some little yellow basket

But not a

White Horse

I'm never gonna ride

The White Horse

I want to be Little Richard

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Even Donald Duck sang

Little Richard

I mean *Quack Quack Quack*

Won't You Come Along with Me?

Now I'm rappin' I'm telling the news

Napster freed me

And I can choose

To have it all

For free download

Yeah I want to live

In music

Teach

Learn

Rejoice

In music

In music I'm free

To be a better me

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TRANSITION

Linda Besner writes . . . "Poetry is art made of words . . . I would love it if all major cities had a poetry museum, where you could go for a visit dressed up in your best all-black clothes. The poems would be widely spaced on clean white walls, big enough for four or five people at once to stand in front of them and read."

I WISH I COULD LIVE (IN A PAINTING)

There is something

About a railroad station

Not only the big pretty ones

Like in Cincinnati saying

"Gateway to the South"

or even Boston's Back Bay with

that heroic Tina Allen sculpture of A.

Philip Randolph

Union Station in DC ... union being

Not only North and South

But working men and women getting

A fair wage for giving

A hard day's work

4NG Fanatics

And those greatest of Black Men . . .

the Pullman Porters . . .

Who set the style . . .

who took America from primitive to privilege

Giving service all through the night

Cooking the meals

Setting the tables

Washing . . .

pressing so others could look

Like gentlemen

Others sorted the mail

Which arrived

On time in the right city

No ZIP code needed thank you

These men could read

And no machine was invited

To that party

There is something about parallel

Lines moving up

And down over

Horizon and dreams never ever

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Touching but rather on

A lonely journey with another

Lonely friend they don't talk

Though a song is sung

Parallel lines . . . not sea

Nor sky . . . hold the dreams

Of women

I wish I lived

In a painting

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